India: Betting on France for military aviation

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India will rely on France to power its military aviation

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A three-part package that includes India's participation in France's sixth-generation fighter program, the procurement of 114 Rafale fighter jets, and the joint development of a jet engine is likely to make France India's primary military aviation partner for decades.
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Despite a last-minute proposal from Rolls-Royce, Safran remains the frontrunner to co-develop a high-thrust engine for India's future domestic fighter jets.
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India is increasingly turning to Europe for defense technologies, as US export controls and strategic unreliability hinder defense cooperation.

India sees France becoming its primary military aviation partner. In August, the Defence Ministry informed parliament that it had begun talks to join France's sixth-generation fighter program led by Dassault. This indicates India has decided not to pursue the UK-Italy-Japan Global Combat Air Programme (GCAP), probably because it would have little to no role in the fighter's development. The GCAP, informally known as the Tempest, is already at the advanced design stage.

France is pressing ahead with its own sixth-generation fighter after the planned joint fighter with Germany under the Future Combat Air System fell through (see: Franco-German divisions likely to end FCAS fighter, not full program , 19 March 2026). It is looking for financing rather than core design input, making India a suitable partner. France's concept for a sixth-generation fighter also matches India's needs: an aircraft that can operate from carriers and carry nuclear weapons.

Meanwhile, the French government has submitted its technical and commercial proposal for India's planned procurement of 114 Dassault Rafales for $34 billion. France's proposal meets most of India's key requirements, and India's Defence Acquisition Council has already authorized the procurement, but negotiations will likely continue for at least a few more months. Indian officials are reportedly eager to finalize the deal before the end of the fiscal year in March 2027, but fiscal pressures after the Iran conflict are likely to affect timing.

The package deal would allow India to develop its defense industrial base. The Rafale proposal would establish a final assembly line in India for 94 of the 114 jets, with each aircraft containing at least 40% domestically produced content. Dassault also plans to establish a maintenance, repair, and overhaul (MRO) facility in India to boost domestic value addition, complementing Safran's existing MRO facility for the Rafale’s 73-kilonewton M88 engine. Additionally, partnerships with MBDA, Thales, and Safran will help Indian firms integrate into European supply chains for missiles, avionics and radars, and engines.

Safran has proposed jointly developing a 120-kilonewton jet engine with the state-owned Defence Research and Development Organisation to power upcoming domestically produced fighters such as the fifth-generation Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA) and the Twin Engine Deck Based Fighter. India has long viewed its lack of a domestic jet engine as a strategic vulnerability, and Safran’s offer to transfer 100% of the engine’s intellectual property rights to India would be a major win for New Delhi. The $7 billion deal also suits Paris: it subsidizes the next generation of French jet engines, which may even power its sixth-generation fighter.

Desire to avoid US dependency informed India’s decision to bet on France. The package deal will place France at the heart of Indian military aviation for decades. The number of Rafales operated by India would rise to 175, possibly more with follow-on orders. The aircraft would comprise roughly a third of the Indian Air Force by the early 2040s and serve as its primary frontline fighter. Furthermore, French engines would power the bulk of India’s fifth-generation fighters, while its sixth-generation fighters would be co-developed with Paris.

The sole competing bid for part of the package is Rolls-Royce's last-minute jet engine proposal in collaboration with the influential Reliance Group. However, Safran remains the favorite to secure the contract. Though Rolls-Royce is believed to have made a more generous offer, India has strategic reservations about an engine vulnerable to US export controls. Additionally, Safran's longstanding partnerships with Indian defense firms give it an edge.

New Delhi is turning to Europe for defense technologies. India’s priority is to develop weapons platforms domestically, but it recognizes the need for foreign partners to access advanced technologies. Over the past two decades, it had seemed the US would emerge as India’s primary defense partner. Yet, poor experiences with US vendors, strict export restrictions, and, most recently, doubts about US strategic reliability under President Donald Trump, have prompted New Delhi to look toward Europe. US equipment, nonetheless, remains central to India’s military airlift and surveillance capabilities, and General Electric engines are set to power current and future models of the domestically produced Tejas light fighter and early variants of the AMCA.

France's longstanding role as a supplier for the Indian Air Force makes deeper aerospace cooperation with Paris a logical next step for New Delhi. But more broadly, Europe is emerging as a major defense partner for India as EU countries relax technology restrictions and strategic ties improve. India also plans to purchase six German Type 214 diesel-electric submarines for $8 billion. These submarines will be built in India, with ThyssenKrupp Marine Systems sharing its air-independent propulsion technology (see: European firms benefit from India’s defense surge , 17 February 2026).

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